PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep CJ-7

1976–1986 · CJ-7 · Renegade · Golden Eagle · Laredo

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame first, everything else second**
  JeepCJ.com's buyer's guide starts with the frame. Probe the front and rear spring-shackle mounts, where mud blocks the drain holes in the boxed rails, the area behind the rear wheels, and all six body mounts. The guide says to check them with a hammer and screwdriver.

- [ ] **Look for cracks around the steering box**
  The guide says the area around the steering box is one of the most common places for a CJ frame to crack, especially on lifted trucks or trucks on big tires. Look for fresh paint, weld beads or splice plates and ask what was done.

- [ ] **Tub, floors and windshield frame**
  Check the rockers, rear corners, wheel wells, the area under the roll bar and the floor; lift any carpet. The bottom of the windshield frame and its hinges rust, often from a leaking defroster. On 1982–86 wide-track trucks, check the front-fender shock towers, which trap water.

- [ ] **Know which gearbox you're buying**
  A T-18A (1977–79) or T-176 (1980–86) is what you want. The SR-4, T-4 and T-5 are light-duty Borg-Warner boxes that Novak says suffer from sheared splines and stretched cases behind the 258. Check the casting number on the driver's side: 13-32 or 13-40 for an SR-4, 13-51 for a T-4, 13-52 for a T-5.

- [ ] **Inspect the AMC 20's two-piece shafts**
  On a stock CJ rear axle the hub is keyed onto the shaft and held with a big nut. If the nut loosens, the key shears and that wheel stops driving. Look for one-piece axle shafts in the receipts, or budget for them. Read the gear-code stamp on the housing to the left of the cover.

- [ ] **Quadra-Trac trucks need a test**
  On gravel, try high and (if fitted) low range and listen for chain noise. The JeepCJ.com guide says the chain stretches, possibly to the point of jumping teeth, if the oil level wasn't kept up. Quadra-Trac trucks have drive plates instead of locking hubs, and the vacuum 'Emergency Drive' control locks the center differential; check that it engages.

- [ ] **Listen to the carburetor**
  Stumbling and stalling at idle usually means a Carter BBD with clogged idle tubes, and its tangle of emissions vacuum hoses is the other usual suspect. Not a deal-breaker, but price in a clean-up or a Weber or EFI swap.

- [ ] **Electrics and emissions bits**
  Duct-tape splices, wire nuts, Scotch-locks and foil-wrapped fuses are warning signs, and most CJ electrical faults come down to rusty grounds. If your state inspects 1980s trucks, check that the TAC air cleaner, EGR, PCV and air-pump hardware are still there; the guide notes air-pump pulleys and brackets are hard to find.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Steering gear**
  1976 · NHTSA 76V-034
- [ ] **Electronic ignition wire connectors**
  1976 (campaign covers 1975–76 Jeeps) · NHTSA 78V-065
- [ ] **Transmission adapter-plate seal**
  1976–1978 · NHTSA 78V-039
- [ ] **Intermediate steering-shaft coupling**
  1978 · NHTSA 78V-049
- [ ] **Tie-rod adjuster clamp bolts**
  1979 · NHTSA 78V-243
- [ ] **Transmission-to-transfer-case gasket**
  1979 · NHTSA 79V-070
- [ ] **Rear seat-belt buckles missing**
  1981 · NHTSA 80V-158
- [ ] **Automatic throttle-control rod spring**
  1981 · NHTSA 81V-015
- [ ] **Manual transmission first-gear lubrication**
  1982 · NHTSA 82V-125

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Body and wheelbase**
  93.5 in wheelbase, 55 in windshield, about 81 in from the door hinge to the rear of the tub, and a 'U'-shaped door opening rather than the CJ-5's inverted 'S'. A CJ-8 looks the same up front but has a 103.5 in wheelbase and a longer rear.
- [ ] **VIN format**
  1976–80 trucks carry a 13-character Jeep VIN; 1981–86 use the 17-character federal format. On 1981–86 VINs the 4th character is the engine (B = 151 Iron Duke, C = 258 six, H = 304 V8, U = AMC 150 four, F = Isuzu diesel), the 5th the transmission/transfer case, characters 6–7 read 87 for a CJ-7, and the 10th is the model year (B = 1981 … G = 1986).
- [ ] **VIN plate locations**
  Main riveted tag on the driver's side firewall near the master cylinder; a partial VIN is stamped on the passenger-side frame rail above the rear wheel. Make sure the tag and the frame stamping agree: a mismatch can mean a swapped tub or a salvage rebuild.
- [ ] **Axles**
  1976–81 narrow-track Dana 30 / AMC 20; 1982–86 wide-track versions; a factory Dana 44 rear only on some late-1986 trucks (and, per Offroaders.com, on some Quadra-Trac trucks as a narrow-track, offset Dana 44). Any other Dana 44 under a CJ-7 is probably an aftermarket swap.
- [ ] **Special editions**
  The 1982 Jamboree has a numbered dash plaque (630 built: 560 Topaz Gold Metallic, 70 Olympic White) and, per Wikipedia, is the only numbered AMC Jeep. The Laredo added highback leather buckets, tilt wheel and chrome bumpers, grille cover and mirrors; Golden Eagles were 304 V8 trucks.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/cj-7/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks